the principle of the Benthamite panopticon – by exposing himself to constant public surveillance, he was able to shake free of both the stifling superstitions of his own society, as well as the oppressive conformities of the modern world, and to move into an arena of freedom that lay beyond the reach of the imperial state and the grip of tradition. His every action, however intimate, was thus infused with a political charge. His dietary 'crankisms' (as he called them), his sexual anxieties and habits, his bowel rhythms, fevers, and black moods, his prayers, spinning, and walks, the drinking of a glass of orange juice to break a fast, gathering up a handful of dusty salt, even his silences themselves, became sources of rumour, legend, and inspiration. In such ways, he made of his physical frame a barometer's needle: by its swings, all could judge for themselves the British Empire's moral health. And the British imperial state, faced with this artful politics of the mundane, found the wind taken from his sails.

To write an autobiography, Gandhi confessed to his readers, was to indulge in something of an unnatural practice, one that was 'peculiar to the West'. Yet his use of the form marks a landmark in non-Western, and specifically Indian, literary invention. He used it to create, in the Indian imagination, the domains of public and private: he reminds his readers that for a 'history' of his public work and life, they should turn to *Satyagraha in South Africa*; here, in the autobiography, they will find only the details of his personal and private life. Yet no sooner were these spheres demarcated than Gandhi was busily blurring them. His use of the genre of autobiography was itself an